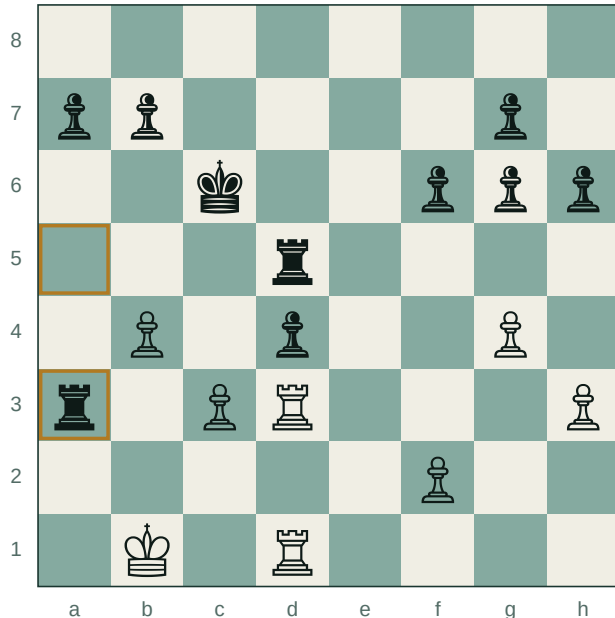


Exposed-king tactics: White, move 31

Exposed-king tactics

White to move



Previous move: 30...Ra3. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

31. c4 Rxd3 32. cxd5+ Kxd5 33. Rxd3

31.c4 The pawn moves from c3 to c4. The changed line means the rook on d3 attacks the rook on a3. Recorded reply: **31...Rxd3**.

32.cxd5+ Check restricts Black to 6 legal replies here. The move also takes the rook on d5. Recorded reply: **32...Kxd5**.

33.Rxd3 The rook captures the rook on d3.

At the end, nominal material is White 9 / Black 7 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +4. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +4: the balance goes from -2 to +2. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A king without pawns is not automatically mated. Count active attackers and examine escapes toward friendly pieces.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

An exposed king gives the attacker checks and access to nearby squares. Coordinate pieces so the checks drive it into a worse net rather than toward safety.

HOW TO LOOK

Inspect open files, diagonals, and unprotected squares around the king. Calculate checks in an order that preserves the attack.

The defending king is on c6. Geometrically undefended: rook on a3. Check for tactical protection.